THE FRAUD FARMING SEASON

PROTECTT.AI'S **MANISH MIMANI** ON HOW SCAMMERS HARVEST INDIA'S FESTIVE SHOPPERS

By **Jayesh Shinde** | editor@digit.in

Every Diwali, India shops like there's no tomorrow, and that's exactly what fraudsters count on. Flash sales, ₹2,000 coupons and "70% off" banners crowd our phones in the run-up to the festive season. Somewhere in that rush, a fake storefront goes up overnight, a "bank executive" calls with an urgent request, and a harmless-looking APK quietly asks for accessibility permissions. By the time the festive glow fades, someone's savings have faded with it.

But the scam playbook has changed. AI now lets bad actors spin up hundreds of lookalike websites in days, clone voices, stage deepfake video calls, and rewrite malware signatures in a couple of hours, a job that used to take far longer. To understand what Indian smartphone users are up against this festive season, Digit spoke to Manish Mimani, Founder and CEO of Protectt.ai, whose AI-native mobile security platform runs on over 900 million devices and secures almost 15 billion app sessions every month. What follows is a candid look at who's being targeted, how the scams work, and what you can do before you tap "Buy Now".

What is Protectt.ai, what sets it apart, and how does it stay ahead of the competition?

Manish: Protectt.ai is an AI-native mobile application security platform. We secure sensitive banking, fintech, UPI and government applications from threats such as system tampering, identity theft and fraud occurring through mobile applications.



MANISH MIMANI
Founder and CEO of Protectt.ai

We have over 900 million devices on our platform through our integration with large banking, fintech and government applications. We secure their customers while they use these mobile applications. On a monthly basis, we secure almost 15 billion mobile application sessions in the Indian market.

What does India's smartphone threat landscape look like, and what risks do these threats carry?

Manish: There are two key trends in the Indian market. Android is open source, so we see a significant number of threats, particularly in the Android ecosystem.

The first is malware. We see different families of malware, including BATs (Banking Access Trojans) and RATs (Root Access Trojans), which target fintech, government and banking applications. Their objective is to steal money and identities. We have seen hundreds of such malware variants circulating, with new variants emerging every month. These malware variants are increasingly capable of taking full control of a device, which we refer to as device takeover.

If such malware is installed on a device, it can potentially execute transactions even while the device is physically with the user. These malware variants can open applications, add beneficiaries and execute transactions, while the OTP is delivered to the user's device. Users may not realise how this is happening because the malware obtains accessibility permissions after installation, uses scripting and instrumentation, and then executes the transaction without them knowing.